

Mesopotamia or Fertile Crescent

The word "mesopotamia" is formed from the ancient words 'meso' meaning between or in the middle of and 'Potamis' meaning river. Mesopotamia often called the "Cradle of Civilization" was situated in the region of the Tigris-Euphrates river system, now mainly in modern Iraq, along with parts of Iran, Syria and Turkey. This civilization is known for several pioneering achievements in various domains such as writing, law, urban planning, and state formation. The Greeks called this area Mesopotamia which means "the land between the rivers". It is also called "the fertile crescent". The Fertile Crescent is a crescent-shaped region in the middle East. Named for its rich soils.

The Sumerians:

By 3000 B.C., many cities had formed in Southern Mesopotamia in a region known as Sumer.

The Sumerian, who lived in the South of the Fertile Crescent in (what is now Iraq and Iran) about 6000 years ago, established the first important civilized society.

The Sumerians Blackheaded People

The Sumerians belonged probably to the Indo-European group. They were the first settlers who occupied the land very near to the Persian Gulf which they called Sumer. The Sumerians (meaning blackheaded people) reclaimed the lands in their region after draining the marshes and brought it under cultiva-

Cultivation
and
Painting
and
craftmanship.

They cultivated wheat and barley and reared cattle, oxen, and donkeys to help them. The Sumerians were also known for their craftsmanship. They made beautiful pots and vessels of alabaster. They also made exquisite ornaments of silver and gold. They excelled in painting and sculpture.

Cuneiform
writing →

(They invented the metal plough which helped farmers in ploughing the land easily. (They invented a system of writing called cuneiform (wedge-shaped writing). As they had no paper to write on, they used clay tablets on which wedge-shaped marks were made with a sharp reed. Thousands of these clay tablets have been discovered which reveal the history of the people. The cuneiform writing consisted of 400 symbols.)

Reckon
Time →

The Sumerians knew how to reckon time. They introduced the system of counting in sixties. They used it for measuring the time, a thing (like sixty seconds make a minute and sixty minutes make an hour) which has come down to us. Another popular unit was the number 12. They maintained regular account of their transactions of business and kept records of tax receipts. They also made progress in engineering science and architecture. The Sumerian builders were the first to use the arch in construction after working out the principle of the key-stone. They used the wheel for making pots and for running their carts and chariots.

Progress in
Engineering
Science and
Architecture

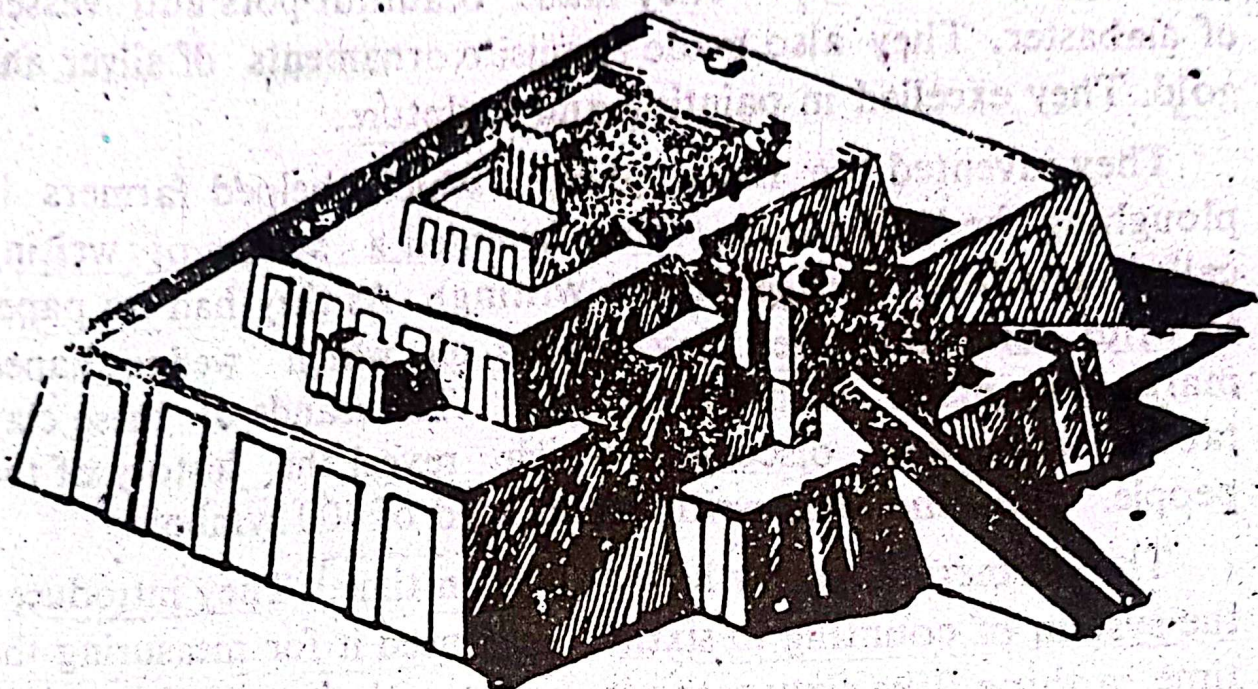
Religion

Like the early Egyptians, the Sumerians worshipped many nature gods and built temples on mounds and hills in their honour. These temples called Ziggurats look like very small pyramids with an ascending staircase in the middle leading to a tower where the idol of God was located. Each city had a patron God. People brought food and animals to the temples to offer them as sacrifice. The priests helped them in conducting prayers and rituals. The priests commanded great respect for they were thought to be representatives of God.

Sumerian
City States

Sumerian City-States Unlike ancient Egyptians who were united under a strong monarchy, the Sumerians developed independent city-states which were governed by patesis, i.e., priest-kings. The most prominent among their city-states were Ur, Kish, Karsa, Lagash and Erech. According to the Holy Bible, Ur was the native city of the Hebrew prophet, Abraham. Besides their religious functions, the priest-kings supervised

revenue collection, irrigation, construction of public buildings and tower-temples (Ziggurat) with the assistance of the nobles.



A Ziggurat reconstructed

The main temple with its tier-terraces was full of markets, banks, factories, and store-houses of food-grains. Thus, the whole economic life of the people was centred in the tower temple. Standard weights and measurements and money economy were in vogue.

Decline (Decline and Fall of Sumerian Kingdoms): The Sumerian city-states were constantly waging wars with one another. Floods often caused heavy damage to these city-states. Added to these two, their country had no physical barriers to prevent the onrush of foreign hordes. So their kingdoms were easily conquered by the most powerful semitic king of the Akkad, Sargon I. The whole of Mesopotamia was unified around 2600 B.C. by this ruler whose subjects adopted the Sumerian culture. After Sargon's death, his empire did not last long. It witnessed frequent attacks by barbarians coming from the desert regions. It was also weakened due to frequent internal rebellions.

Innovative Farming

They were mainly farmer who

planted crops in the rich mud that was left after the rivers flooded each spring. They knew how to make tools of bronze as well as of stone. They had powerful leaders probably priests but later kings who organized big projects such as digging canals for irrigation and also making sure that the whole country worked together. They also decided after consulting the gods when to plant and harvest the crops.

Inventions & Discoveries

Sumerian invented the world's first writing by making marks on blocks of soft clay which were then dried in the sun or baked in the fire to make them permanent. This writing which was called cuneiform was used to keep records of the goods which they had bought or sold as well as the country's laws. Later it was used

for recording stories, especially about the adventures of the hero ~~god~~ Gilgamesh. Life - at least for the rich - became very comfortable in the Fertile Crescent as discovery followed the discovery.

The Sumerians invented wheels and carts which made transport so much quicker and easier.

The Sumerians fitted the sails to the boats - in this way, people had succeeded to do their work with the help of natural forces.

They had fine pottery made on a wheel, good furniture, musical instruments and beautiful jewellery and statues.

The peasants found out how to harness animals to ploughs, instead of cultivating the land with hand hoes, and this allowed them to grow much more grain.

The grain and the things made by the craftsmen were traded up and down the river and exchanged for stone, wood and metals which were not easily available in Sumeria.

The priests began the world's first Science. They studied the stars to forecast when the floods would come and when the planting time would begin.

The Sumerians invented the clocks - some sundials, and others were water clocks.

They worked out a system of arithmetic so that they could calculate numbers for taxes and trading.

As the writing was common now, so all of these things could be written down and passed on to other people.

Education

they also trained to be scribes. Every day for many hours they copied the signs of the Cuneiform Script, trying to master hundreds of words and phrases.

In ancient Mesopotamia, only boys from wealthy and high-ranking families went to the "edubba" which means "tablet house".

At the edubba — the world's first school — boys studied reading, writing and mathematics and